

LW6100E: ADVANCED LEGAL RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

Effective Term

Semester A 2026/27

Part I Course Overview

Course Title

Advanced Legal Research Methodology

Subject Code

LW - Law

Course Number

6100E

Academic Unit

School of Law (FL)

College/School

School of Law (FL)

Course Duration

One Semester

Credit Units

3

Level

P5, P6 - Postgraduate Degree

Medium of Instruction

English

Medium of Assessment

English

Prerequisites

Nil

Precursors

Nil

Equivalent Courses

LW6700/LW8700D/LW8709D Advanced Legal Research Methodology
LW6700 and LW8700D are the old course codes for LW8709D

Exclusive Courses

LW6703 Globalisation and Legal Research Methodology

Part II Course Details

Abstract

This module enhances students' skills in research and writing. It provides an overview of the skills in relation to legal reasoning, research methods, and legal writing, combining theoretical insights and practical applications. The course covers understanding the nature of studying law and legal reasoning, the distinct features of legal research, formulating legal questions, research design, ensuring originality, exploring various research methods, sourcing research materials, legal referencing and citation best practices, preventing plagiarism, maintaining academic integrity, and integrating technology into legal research. Students will sharpen their critical thinking abilities. Active participation in class discussions is encouraged. Artificial intelligence (AI) will be carefully used to foster curiosity, skill-building, and creative problem-solving.

Course Intended Learning Outcomes (CILOs)

CILOs		Weighting (if app.)	DEC-A1	DEC-A2	DEC-A3
1	Understand and demonstrate various kinds of research skills essential for conducting legal research at an advanced level.		x	x	x
2	Demonstrate critical thinking and reasoning skills through paper writing and class discussions		x	x	x

A1: Attitude

Develop an attitude of discovery/innovation/creativity, as demonstrated by students possessing a strong sense of curiosity, asking questions actively, challenging assumptions or engaging in inquiry together with teachers.

A2: Ability

Develop the ability/skill needed to discover/innovate/create, as demonstrated by students possessing critical thinking skills to assess ideas, acquiring research skills, synthesizing knowledge across disciplines or applying academic knowledge to real-life problems.

A3: Accomplishments

Demonstrate accomplishment of discovery/innovation/creativity through producing /constructing creative works/new artefacts, effective solutions to real-life problems or new processes.

Learning and Teaching Activities (LTAs)

LTAs		Brief Description	CILO No.	Hours/week (if applicable)
1	Lectures	Weekly lectures on key topics in legal research.	1, 2	
2	Research Proposal	Students are required to conduct independent research and write a research proposal.	1, 2	
3	Class Presentation	Students are required to give one class presentation on their research project/proposal and its methodology.	1, 2	

Assessment Tasks / Activities (ATs)

ATs	CILO No.	Weighting (%)	Remarks ("- for nil entry)	Allow Use of GenAI?
1	A research proposal of 4,000-6,000 words	1, 2	60 Students are encouraged to critically explore working with AI. AI could be used to assist in: 1. Searching and gathering sources; 2. Critically exploring and creatively connecting distinct ideas; 3. Learning to co-create with AI while avoiding cognitive and agency offloading. Students remain responsible for all presented and submitted work and must critically evaluate and meaningfully revise any AI-generated material. They must verify all sources, citations, quotations, and substantive claims, and meaningfully disclose their use of AI.	Yes

2	Class participation and presentation	1, 2	40	Students are encouraged to critically explore working with AI. AI could be used to assist in: 1. Searching and gathering sources; 2. Critically exploring and creatively connecting distinct ideas; 3. Learning to co-create with AI while avoiding cognitive and agency offloading. Students remain responsible for all presented and submitted work and must critically evaluate and meaningfully revise any AI-generated material. They must verify all sources, citations, quotations, and substantive claims, and meaningfully disclose their use of AI.	Yes
---	--------------------------------------	------	----	---	-----

Continuous Assessment (%)

100

Minimum Continuous Assessment Passing Requirement (%)

40

Additional Information for ATs

Students may complete the research proposal and presentation individually or in pairs. Pairs are the default and encouraged. A student wishing to work individually must notify the Course Leader via email, with a brief reason, by the end of week 3. NB: The Course Leader may limit the number of individual projects to accommodate the presentation schedule.

Applicable to students admitted before Semester A 2022/23 and in Semester A 2024/25 & thereafter

Students must obtain a minimum mark of 40% in both research proposal, class participation and presentation, and an overall mark of 40% in order to pass the course.

Applicable to students admitted from Semester A 2022/23 to Summer Term 2024

Students must obtain a minimum mark of 50% in both research proposal, class participation and presentation, and an overall mark of 50% in order to pass the course.

Assessment Rubrics (AR)

Assessment Task

Class participation and presentation (for students admitted before Semester A 2022/23 and in Semester A 2024/25 & thereafter)

Criterion

Students must attend at least 70% of the classes (lectures, seminars, presentations).

Excellent

(A+, A, A-) Strong evidence of original thinking; good organisation, capacity to analyse and synthesize; superior grasp of subject matter; evidence of extensive knowledge base.

Good

(B+, B, B-) Evidence of grasp of subject, some evidence of critical capacity and analytical ability; reasonable understanding of issues; evidence of familiarity with literature.

Fair

(C+, C, C-) Reasonable evidence of understanding of the subject; ability to develop solutions to simple problems.

Marginal

(D) Core familiarity with the subject matter.

Failure

(F) Little evidence of familiarity with the subject matter; weakness in critical and analytical skills; limited or irrelevant use of literature.

Assessment Task

A research proposal of 4,000-6,000 words (for students admitted before Semester A 2022/23 and in Semester A 2024/25 & thereafter)

Criterion

- Selection of topic
- Formulation of aims and objectives of research
- Design of proposed research and literature review
- Methods of analysis
- Literature review and bibliography
- Timetable

Excellent

(A+, A, A-) Strong evidence of original thinking; good organisation, capacity to analyse and synthesize; superior grasp of subject matter; evidence of extensive knowledge base.

Good

(B+, B, B-) Evidence of grasp of subject, some evidence of critical capacity and analytical ability; reasonable understanding of issues; evidence of familiarity with literature.

Fair

(C+, C, C-) Reasonable evidence of understanding of the subject; ability to develop solutions to simple problems

Marginal

(D) Core familiarity with the subject matter

Failure

(F) Little evidence of familiarity with the subject matter; weakness in critical and analytical skills; limited or irrelevant use of literature.

Assessment Task

Class participation and presentation (for students admitted from Semester A 2022/23 to Summer Term 2024)

Criterion

Students must attend at least 70% of the classes (lectures, seminars, presentations).

Excellent

(A+, A, A-) High

Good

(B+, B) Significant

Marginal

(B-, C+, C) Moderate

Failure

(F) Inadequate

Assessment Task

A research proposal of 4,000-6,000 words (for students admitted from Semester A 2022/23 to Summer Term 2024)

Criterion

- Selection of topic
- Formulation of aims and objectives of research including reasons for the selection of topic, why it is worthy of study, research question(s) etc.
- Procedure including design of proposed research and literature review
- Data collection and methods of analysis
- Literature review and bibliography
- Timetable

Excellent

(A+, A, A-) High

Good

(B+, B) Significant

Marginal

(B-, C+, C) Moderate

Failure

(F) Inadequate

Part III Other Information

Keyword Syllabus

The course covers the following topics:

1. Nature and objectives of legal research
2. Argument making, critical thinking, and reasoning
3. Doctrinal research
4. Empirical legal research
5. Comparative law research
6. Legal theories
7. Interdisciplinary research
8. Artificial intelligence and legal research

Reading List

Compulsory Readings

Title	
1	Compulsory course materials will be provided via Canvas throughout the course. Such materials may include readings as well as audio and video files.

Additional Readings

Title	
1	Recommended Readings:
2	Lee Epstein and Andrew D. Martin, <i>An Introduction to Empirical Legal Research</i> (Oxford University Press, 2014)
3	Frans L. Leeuw (with Hans Schmeets), <i>Empirical Legal Research: A Guidance Book for Lawyers, Legislators and Regulators</i> (Edward Elgar: 2016)
4	Watkins, Dawn and Burton, Mandy <i>Research Methods in Law</i> (Routledge, 2018)
5	Mike McConville and Wing Hong Chui, <i>Research Methodologies for Law</i> (Edinburgh University Press, 2007)
6	Simon Halliday and Patrick Schmidt, <i>Conducting Law and Society Research</i> (Cambridge University Press, 2009)
7	Michael Head and Scott Mann, <i>Law in Perspective: Ethics, Society and Critical Thinking</i> (UNSW Press, 2005)
8	Kenneth J. Vandeveld, <i>Thinking Like a Lawyer</i> (Westview Press, 2010)
9	Friedrich V. Kratochwil, <i>Rules, Norms and Decisions: On the Conditions of Practical and Legal Reasoning in International Relations and Domestic Affairs</i> (Cambridge University Press, 1989)
10	Wayne C. Booth et al., <i>The Craft of Research</i> (University of Chicago Press, 2017)